



Your kid finished the book. Now what?

There are two children who finish a series, and they need opposite things. One tore through it and wants the shelf refilled. One stopped somewhere around book three and never said so. Both of them “finished.” Here is how I tell them apart.

THE QUESTION I ASK AT MY MARKET TABLE

“How did she do reading it?”

Not *did she like it*. How did she *do*. That is the whole diagnostic, and it costs nothing.

If you would rather hear it from the reader than about them, you could ask casually, not as a test: *what happened in the last one?* A child who flew through it will tell you, probably at length. A child who stalled will shrug, or stop at chapter two.

IF THEY TELL YOU EVERYTHING

Go up.

They built real momentum. Hand them the next rung and stay out of the way. They do not need new characters or a new world, only more of what they already like.

- ☐ Magic Tree House: Merlin Missions
The same Jack and Annie, longer books
- ☐ Magic Tree House Fact Trackers
For the kid who cared about the mummies
- ☐ Ranger in Time
Kate Messner · Scholastic
- ☐ I Survived
Lauren Tarshis · listed ages 7 and up, and the subjects are real disasters. Read the first one alongside them.

IF YOU GET A SHRUG

Go sideways, not up.

Harder is the wrong direction. What they need is to finish something. Anything. A whole book, cover to cover, and the feeling that comes with closing it.

Find something short and real that they will finish this week. Let them feel the ending. Then go up.

- ☐ Adventures of Charlotte & Henry
Mine. Written in verse: white space, an illustration every chapter, short lines built for easy wins
- ☐ The Magic School Bus Chapter Books
Scholastic · adventure with real science
- ☐ Dragon Masters
Branches / Scholastic · short and heavily illustrated
- ☐ Flat Stanley
Jeff Brown · funnier and lighter, same short chapters

All eight are in the free **Reading Ladder** one pager.

The one thing I would not do is treat the shrug as a verdict on the child. It is a verdict on the book, and books are replaceable.

The long version, with both lists: BraveHeartsPublishing.com/blog/what-to-read-after-magic-tree-house/